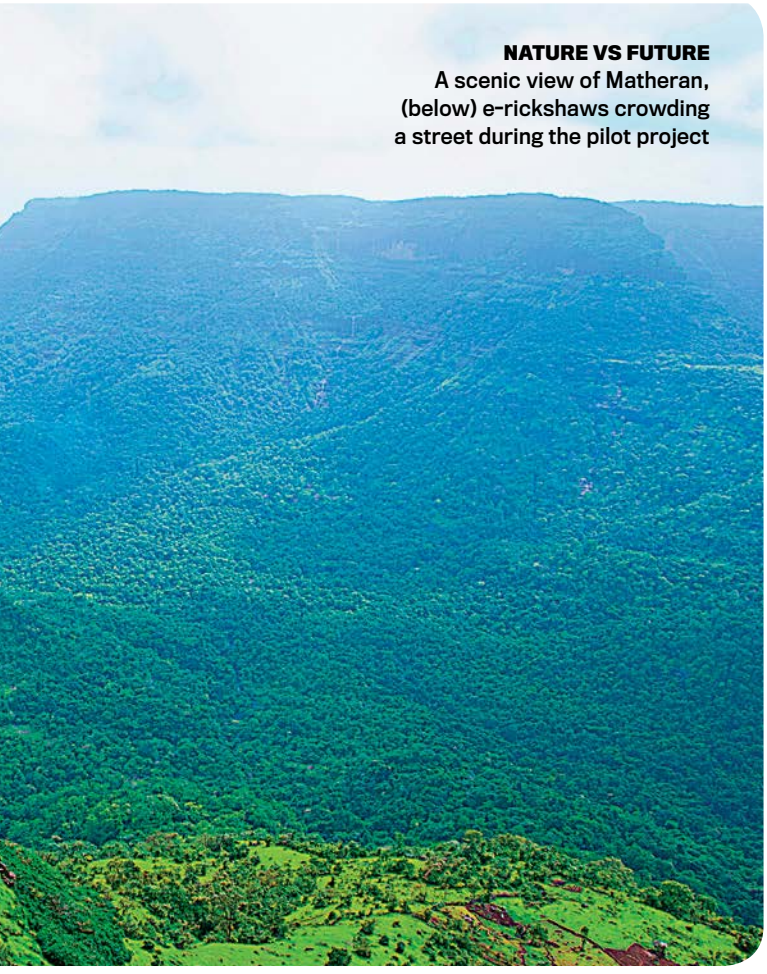


NATURE VS FUTURE
A scenic view of Matheran, (below) e-rickshaws crowding a street during the pilot project

SHUTTERSTOCK



A GREEN GETAWAY

Nestled in the Western Ghats, Matheran is a hill station, about 90 km from Mumbai

800
METRE
Elevation

7.25
SQ. KM
Area

4,393
POPULATION
(2011 census)

788,867
TOURISTS
(in 2022)

- **All motor vehicles barred, except ambulances/ fire tenders, since the town's inception during the British Raj**
- Also declared an Ecologically Sensitive Zone in 2003, banning development activities harmful to environment
- Both tourists and locals have to park their vehicles at Dasturi Naka, about 3 km away, before beginning the ascent
- Modes of transport include 460 horses and 94 hand-pulled rickshaws (which charge around Rs 500 per person)
- Goods are brought uphill by 127 licensed porters and over 250 ponies
- A narrow-gauge toy train provides limited services to the nearest railhead of Neral, covering 21 km in over two hours

accepted that a three-month period is too short for judging the suitability of e-rickshaws," says K.P. Bakshi, a former IAS officer who heads the committee. "So, the committee felt [the trial] should go through the entire cycle of one year, [covering] the rainy season, tourist season and non-tourist season. Thus, we will know the real impact, advantages and disadvantages."

Ask Shraddha Ramane, 27, who teaches at the local convent school, where her daughter Unnati is a senior kindergarten student. Going to school is a daily ordeal for the five-year-old girl, who has to walk four kilometres all the way to her school, and then cover the same distance—again on foot—on her way back in the afternoon. "These long walks leave her so tired," says her mother, "that she ends up sleeping for three hours when she comes back. After that, she's left with no time to play or participate in other extra-curricular activities." Kalpana Patil, the headmistress of a local high school, says the brief trial run of the e-rickshaws demonstrated what a boon they can be for school kids, some